



Hongwu's final resting place, the Xiaoling Mausoleum, lies at the foot of the Purple Mountain in Nanjing, and is guarded by an avenue of stone statues of pairs of animals, including camels.

regarded China as the center of the world, and the later Ming saw no reason to encourage further maritime contact. The Chinese did not regard relations with foreign powers as possible on an equal basis: where diplomatic relations were conducted, the foreigners were considered (by the Ming, at least) as tributaries. The confidence and stability of the Ming bureaucracy also created a sense of self-sufficiency, with little use for external influences.

Ocean-going vessels were made to report all the cargo they landed, and private maritime trade was periodically banned (until it was legalized again in 1567 for all except trade with Japan). In Beijing, a shopkeeper's unauthorized contact with foreigners could result in the confiscation of his stock.

Diplomatic isolation was reinforced by military uncertainty: Annam became independent once more in 1428, while huge resources were devoted to containing the threat posed by the Mongol tribes on China's northern borders. In 1449, Emperor Zhengtong personally led a disastrous expedition against the Mongol leader Esen Khan in which the majority of the 500,000 Chinese soldiers died of hunger, were picked off by the enemy, or perished in a final battle as they retreated.

Extending the Great Wall

In the 1470s, the building of the final stages of the Great Wall—began by the Qin dynasty in the 3rd century BCE—was not only a bid to prevent a similar disaster, but also to compensate for the Ming's waning energy. Like their predecessors, they were

unable to absorb the lands of the nomadic groups to the north of the border, or to send out expeditions that had any lasting effect on discouraging their raids. Therefore, a fixed, strongly garrisoned border defense was the best compromise.

During the 16th century, a succession of short-lived emperors who were dominated by their consorts, mothers, or by eunuch (castrated) advisers, was capped by the long reign of Wanli (1573–1620), who simply withdrew from public life entirely: for the last decades of his reign, he refused even to meet with his ministers. The dynasty began to decline: the machinery of government faltered and the army had little strength to respond to the serious threat posed by the Jurchen in Manchuria (now in northeast China). In 1619, this tribal people, who later renamed themselves Manchu, began to encroach on China's northern borders.

Global trade

Economically, however, Ming China's great productivity was a magnet for European maritime states seeking new commercial connections in East Asia, and in the early 16th century, European traders finally reached the coast of China. In 1514, a Portuguese fleet appeared off Canton (now Guangzhou) in the south, and by 1557, Portugal had established a permanent base at Macao. Spanish and Portuguese merchants (the former operating from Nagasaki in Japan and Manila in the Philippines)—and from 1601, the Dutch—secured an important share in trade with China.

Even though Ming policy discouraged foreign maritime trade, individual Chinese merchants had participated actively in the revived economy. Before long there were flourishing Chinese colonies in Manila and on Java in Indonesia, near the Dutch-controlled trading city of Batavia, and Chinese merchants controlled a large share of local trade in Southeast Asia. The technical sophistication of the Chinese porcelain industry under the Ming led for the first time to the mass production of ceramics for export to European markets.

The effects, though, of this growth in trade were not wholly positive: while a huge influx of silver from the Americas and